Padshah. ‘Although I was sober and the elephant was very easy to handle and responded well to my will,’ was Akbar’s surprising confession to his son Jahangir many years later, ‘I pretended that I was dead drunk and the elephant was uncontrollable.’ Hearing the commotion, Ataka Khan rushed out and threw his turban to the ground in horror, while the people raised their hands to the heavens and shouted out for divine help. Akbar saw his Ataka and irritatedly shouted at him: ‘If you don’t stop acting like that, I’ll throw myself from this elephant right now.’

Akbar now found himself in a situation which was not easy to defuse because he could not admit to the onlookers that ‘neither was I drunk nor was the elephant out of control’. As the spectators, now mute, watched in terror, the routed Ranbagh ran down towards the Yamuna, towards a bobbing bridge of boats. Ranbagh, followed by Hawai, lumbered onto the unsteady bridge and the skiffs swayed and creaked and finally collapsed, as the men holding onto the boats jumped away in alarm into the warm river. The elephants swam across the river and Ranbagh escaped into the forest and Akbar at last halted Hawai. Even Abu’l Fazl admitted that to the superficial observer it might seem as though Akbar ‘must have some sort of imbalance in his mind’ for it was unheard of for rulers to risk their lives in this way. But for Akbar, radiating an almost uncontrollable physical energy, these confrontations with his own mortality were a test, a challenge to the divine to either take him or spare his life ‘for we cannot bear the burden of existence without divine pleasure’.

*There is uncertainty about her actual position. Some sources claim she was a queen, others that she was a favoured dancing girl.

*The members of Jiji Anaga and Shamsuddin Ataka Khan’s family were so large that they were collectively known as the Ataka Khail, or Ataka clan.